



SURVIVE SWEDEN

Your complete guide to everyday Swedish.
Phrases, pronunciation, and culture tips
that actually work.

DIGITAL GUIDE + AUDIO PRONUNCIATION

For complete beginners — no prior Swedish knowledge needed.



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How the audio works: Each chapter has a QR code at the bottom. Scan it with your phone camera to hear every phrase pronounced by a real person — not a robot. You can also listen while reading to practice along.

Swedish in 5 Minutes

Everything you need to know about how Swedish sounds — before you learn a single word. Master these basics and you'll already sound better than 90% of tourists.

The Swedish Alphabet — What's Different

Swedish has 29 letters. The 26 you know, plus three extra at the end: Å, Ä, and Ö. These aren't decorations — they're completely separate letters with their own sounds. Getting these right is your first big win.

Å å

/oh/ — like the 'o' in 'or'

Think of it as a round 'o' sound. Å for 'år' (year).

Ä ä

/eh/ — like the 'e' in 'bed'

Open your mouth wider than a normal 'e'. Ä for 'äpple' (apple).

Ö ö

/ur/ — like the 'u' in 'burn'

Round your lips while saying 'e'. Ö for 'öl' (beer).

CULTURE TIP

These three letters come AFTER Z in the alphabet. So in a Swedish dictionary or phone book, Å comes after Z, then Ä, then Ö. This matters when you're looking things up!

Sounds That Will Trip You Up

Swedish has a few sounds that don't exist in English or Spanish. Don't stress about perfecting them — Swedes will understand you even if you're just close. But knowing about them helps a lot.

The SJ-sound (sju, skjorta, stjärna)

/hwuh/ – a soft hushing sound

Like a whispered 'who'. This is THE hardest Swedish sound. Even some Swedes debate how to pronounce it. Don't overthink it.

K before soft vowels (E, I, Y, Ä, Ö)

/sh/ – not a hard 'k'

Kör = 'shur' (drive), not 'kor'. Kök = 'shuk' (kitchen). This catches everyone off guard.

G before soft vowels (E, I, Y, Ä, Ö)

/y/ – soft like 'yes'

Göra = 'yuh-ra' (to do). Gärna = 'yair-na' (gladly).

J — always a 'y' sound

/y/ – like 'yes', never like 'jam'

Jag = 'yah' (I/me). Juice = 'yoos'. Never a hard J.

R — rolled or tapped

Rolled like in Spanish or Italian

Not the English R. In southern Sweden it's more guttural (French-style).

The Melody — Swedish Pitch Accent

Swedish is called a 'singing language' because words have a musical rise and fall. You don't need to master this right now, but knowing it exists helps you sound more natural. Listen to how Swedes go UP and then DOWN within words — it's like a little wave.

Accent 1 (single tone): Anden

One smooth rise — means 'the duck'

A single melodic movement. Most one-syllable words use this.

Accent 2 (double tone): Anden

Rise-fall-rise — means 'the spirit/ghost'

A double melodic bounce. Same word, different melody = different meaning!

CULTURE TIP

Don't panic about pitch accent. Swedes will understand you from context even if your melody is off. It's like saying 'tomAYto' vs 'tomAHto' in English — different but still clear. Just listen to how Swedes speak and it'll start to feel natural over time.

Quick Wins — Sound Swedish Instantly

Even before learning phrases, these tricks make you sound less like a tourist immediately. Small adjustments, big difference.

Don't pronounce the 'g' at the end of -ig / -ag

Jag = 'yah' — NOT 'yag'

The silent g rule. Rolig (funny) = 'roo-lee', not 'roo-lig'. Tråkig (boring) = 'troh-kee'.

'O' often sounds like 'oo'

Bok = 'book', not 'bock'

Swedish 'o' is usually more rounded than English. Sol (sun) = 'sool'. Bro (bridge) = 'broo'.

Stress is usually on the first syllable

STOCK-holm, not Stock-HOLM

Put emphasis on the beginning of words. GOTH-en-burg. MAL-mö. AH-landa.

'RS' together makes a 'sh' sound

Varsågod = 'vah-SHOH-good'

When R and S meet (even across words), they merge into 'sh'. Förslag = 'fuh-SHLAG'.

Swedish 'U' is unique

/ew/ – round your lips tightly

Hus (house) = 'hews'. Ful (ugly) = 'fewl'. Nowhere near the English 'uh'.

CULTURE TIP

Don't try to be perfect. Swedes genuinely appreciate ANY effort to speak Swedish, even if your pronunciation is rough. Most will compliment you and then switch to English — don't let that stop you! Say 'Jag vill öva min svenska' (I want to practice my Swedish) and they'll usually stick with Swedish for you.

Listen to This Chapter

Scan the QR code to hear every phrase pronounced naturally. No robot voices — just real Swedish.

Next up: Chapter 02 — Day One Essentials

The 30 phrases you'll use every single day in Sweden.